relationships with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Central government. This posting, including contributing to and implementing the recommendations of the eleventh and twelfth Finance Commissions, provided a solid underpinning to my understanding of fiscal federal issues, in the Indian and global settings.

As the joint secretary in charge of the newly launched Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (RKVY), I had the opportunity to work with all the Indian states in the widest amplitude of the agriculture and allied sector, which included animal husbandry and fisheries.

As the Cabinet Secretariat is the fulcrum to process all proposals going to the Cabinet and Cabinet Committees, the posting as joint secretary and, later, additional secretary in the Cabinet Secretariat provided me a ringside view of discussions in the Cabinet. Numerous CoSs held in many economic sectors during this period—telecommunication, information technology (IT), disaster management, investment promotion, environmental issues—widened my understanding of the Indian economy.

The icing on the cake came in the form of my appointment as Secretary Economic Affairs in 2017. I wrote the drafts of three budget speeches (2018–19, 2019–20 [interim] and 2019–20) and finalized the set of accompanying budget documents. National budgets are the instruments of national fiscal policy management and important vehicles to initiate economic policy reforms.

Three Key Insights

My participation in numerous economy-related engagements during my long public service and study and reflections in the past two years after my voluntary retirement in 2019 have given me three key insights into the economy.

First, an economy is all about production and distribution of goods, services and assets or the economic value added, and a correctly measured